platform has. People complain on day one, then never leave.

What won them over was a long run of small decisions that made the store feel like it was on the player's side. A refund policy that lets you hand back a game that turned out bad. Cloud saves, Workshop mods, family sharing and rupee pricing for Indian players instead of a guessing game with the dollar rate. Newell also argued years ago that piracy is a service problem rather than a price problem, and Steam is that argument turned into a shop. Make buying easier than stealing and people buy, then buy again, then collect four hundred games they will never open.

Then there is the Steam Summer Sale, a yearly festival where the PC community agrees to overspend together. Wishlists, discount alerts and a backlog guilt trip all feed it. Nobody has ever left a Steam sale with only the one game they came for.

Then there is Steam support, which is so good that it has become a meme. Most companies will make you fight a chatbot for a refund. Steam will send the CIA to look for the hacker.

The critics have a point too. Steam keeps a standard 30 percent cut, which shrinks for the biggest sellers, and lawsuits in the US and the UK accuse Valve of using that dominance to keep prices high. Epic showed up with a 12 percent cut and a free game every week, then paid for exclusives, which gamers tend to take personally. Steam mostly shrugged and watched most people stay. Toll booth or infrastructure depends on which side of the checkout you stand on. Newell's trick is that most players feel like they are standing beside him.

The hardware bet

Valve could have stayed a very comfortable software company. It kept trying hardware instead, and for years that went badly. The first Steam Machines in 2015 flopped, and most people forgot they existed. Then the Steam Deck arrived in 2022 at $399, a handheld that ran PC games on Linux with Proton doing the translation work. Newell spent years hearing that Linux gaming was a joke, then watched every Windows handheld copy his work.

The open approach matters here. Valve built SteamOS on Linux, funded the compatibility layer that lets Windows games run on it and now lets other companies ship handhelds with it. In an industry that loves walled gardens, Valve keeps opening the gate.

2026 is the sequel, and the price tags are the plot twist. The Steam Controller landed in May at $99. The Steam Machine followed on June 29 at $1,049 for the 512 GB model, which



a heck of a price tag. Valve blamed the global memory shortage, the same squeeze that pushed Deck prices up by as much as $300. The Steam Frame VR headset got its price on September 14 at $1,059 for 256 GB and $1,299 for 1 TB, sold through a reservation queue. The Machine promises six times the power of a Deck and runs SteamOS, so it behaves like a console that happens to be a PC. The Frame can stream your library from a PC or run games on its own Snapdragon chip, and reviews were mixed, with praise for the design.

That is a real test for a company that runs on goodwill. Players forgive a lot for a store that treats them well, but a headset that costs more than most consoles asks for trust.

The Half-Life 3 Problem

Valve runs on a flat structure with no formal bosses, and the desks have wheels so people can roll toward whichever project looks fun. The company has only a few hundred employees, which makes its revenue per head look like a typo. The employee handbook that explained all this became required reading for startup founders. It is also why Valve can produce a Portal, a Left 4 Dead and a Dota 2, and why it has not produced Half-Life 3 since Episode Two ended on a cliffhanger in 2007. Valve cannot count to three, goes the joke, and the studio has let it run for nearly two decades. The VR game Alyx in 2020 proved the series was alive, which only made the wait louder.

There are rougher edges too. Counter-Strike skins grew into a trading economy that gambling critics and regulators keep circling, and Valve has taken heat for how slowly it moved on that. The love is real, but it is not totally unconditional.

The unfinished verdict

Newell's current side quest is Starfish Neuroscience, a brain-computer interface company he co-founded to build chips that talk to the brain. Of course the man who dragged PC gaming onto the couch wants to plug it into your skull next.

What stands out about Newell is how little charisma he needed. Other tech founders built their legends on stages and in feuds. Newell built his on a storefront that mostly stayed out of the way and treated players like customers who might leave. That habit now has to survive the AI memory price hikes, antitrust lawsuits and a $1,000 headset.

If it does, Valve will be the rare company that got worshipped for being convenient. And maybe that is the uncomfortable part. People may not love Steam as much as they love the three hundred games they cannot afford to leave behind.